

## Why reference managers?

The reasons for using reference managers are listed below:

- Insertion and removal of citations becomes simple. In case of numbered citations, i.e., in the places where references are made to other material, numbers are inserted in brackets like [1],[2], etc. While revising the article, if you need to remove or add a citation, then all the following numbers need to be modified. You will understand the painstaking nature of this task, when the article being written involves a large number of references. If you are using a reference manager, then the numbers are incremented or decremented automatically.
- Another important reason for using a reference manager is to handle the reference list format properly. There are various format types like the APA style, MLA style, Chicago Manual of Style, the Harvard style, etc. Generally, different publishers follow different styles, and they mandate that the content writers adhere to these formats strictly. Hence, if you have to change from one format to another, it would consume hours of intensive and focused attention. Whereas, if you use reference managers, switching from one format to another can be done with a single click.
- Reference managers come handy in organising the collection of reference material gathered from various sources in a single window. Most of the reference managers have a search feature, which facilitates the search through the collections in the library.
- Reference managers enable collaboration with people of similar interests and also help in sharing resources. They facilitate syncing between multiple computers that an author may use.

## The choices

A quick Google search on reference managers will reveal that there are umpteen choices. Complete coverage of all reference managers is beyond the scope of this article. Figure 1 illustrates the prominent choices in the world of reference managers.

While the spectrum of reference managers provides users with options, it also makes choosing one a difficult task. Most reference managers provide the basic functionality of keeping the references and adding the citations. Apart from this, each reference manager has its own unique feature, which could be mobile support, search, collaboration, etc. So users have to make an informed decision while choosing a reference manager.

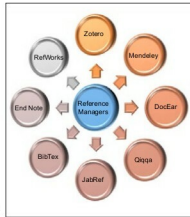


Figure 1: Reference manager choices



Figure 2: Factors to consider

## Factors to consider

Indeed, there are many factors that need to be considered. Figure 2 illustrates various factors that affect the choice of a reference manager.

- **Cost:** As with any other decision-making process, cost plays an important role in selecting a reference manager if you plan to choose proprietary tools like EndNote, RefWorks, etc. Some of the reference managers have a hybrid plan. They provide some features for free and premium features need to be paid for. Mendeley, which was purchased by Elsevier in 2013, and Qiqqa may be categorised under the hybrid category. If you opt for a free and open source product like Zotero, the cost factor becomes insignificant.
- **OS support:** If you happen to use multiple operating systems across various devices, then you have to check whether the reference manager supports all the OSs that you use. For example, EndNote supports Windows and Mac. If you are a Linux user, then this might become a bottleneck. Reference managers like Zotero, DocEar, Mendeley, etc, support Windows, Linux and Mac.
- **Mobile phone support:** Smartphones have become a great productivity tool. If you want to work with your reference managers from anywhere, then mobile phone support needs to be considered. Reference managers like Qiqqa provide an Android version. Mendeley versions are available for the iPad, iPhone, etc. For Zotero, there are applications like Scanner, Zandy, etc, which are available in the Google Play store.
- **Word processor support:** Your manuscript will be created using the word processing tools of software suites like MS Office, Libre Office, etc. The reference manager's integration with word processing tools is a significant factor to consider. For example, Zotero supports various word processors like MS Word, Libre Office, Open Office, Google Docs, etc. If you are a LaTeX user, then reference managers like JabRef are handy.
- **Number of reference styles:** There are thousands of referencing styles. If you need to prepare manuscripts that